

Bad Luck Strikes Fiorillo, UTEP

By MARK LEIBSON

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Nick Fiorillo is seriously thinking of having "The Hard Luck Kid" printed on the back of his University of Texas at El Paso baseball uniform.

An infield fly dropped by first baseman Jerry Walker opened the gates for four unearned Arizona State runs which enabled the Sun Devils to beat the Miners 6-4 Friday in their Western Athletic Conference opener at Dudley Field.

"It's typical," said Fiorillo, referring

to Walker's muff which allowed ASU to break a 2-2 deadlock in the eighth inning. "That's the way my luck has been going all year long. God, I wanted to beat them so bad. What can I say?"

The Sun Devils' Jamie Allen was on second base with two outs when Dave Hudgens looped a high fly to the first base side of the pitcher's mound. Walker ran in for the ball but it bounced off his glove, allowing Allen to score the go-ahead run.

Fiorillo's frustrations were evident

when he hit the next ASU player with a pitch and delivered a two-strike homer to Richard Stahl.

For Miner coach Andy Cohen, it was another disappointing conference defeat. "This game reminded me of what we did against New Mexico a couple of years ago when our first and third basemen collided on an infield fly with the bases loaded. It's a hell of a way to lose a game. It really takes the starch out of you."

UTEP controlled the game through the first six innings, scoring single runs in the first and third innings on

Walker singles.

Fiorillo showed his cool earlier in the game when he struck out the side in the second inning after Chris Bando, brother of major leaguer Sal Bando, tripled to lead off the frame.

Hubie Brooks closed the gap to 2-1 in the fourth with a towering home run over the fence in left field.

Both teams return to Dudley Field for an 11 a.m. doubleheader which will conclude the three-game series. The loss was UTEP's third in a row, dropping its record to 21-11. ASU is 29-6 for the season and 1-0 in WAC.